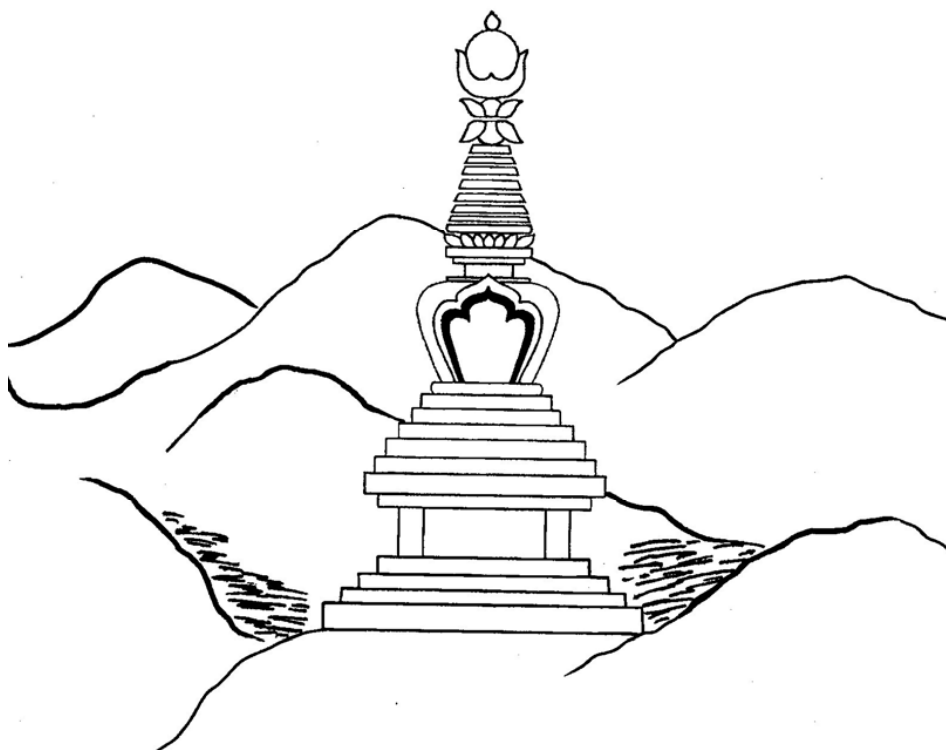


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BOOK REVIEW

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Reviewed by SAMAR SINHA
Sikkim University

The Politics of Language Oppression in Tibet by Gerald Roche is about the politics that underlie the language endangerment, in the context of a global language crisis. Roche acknowledges that *endangerment* linguistics has been fruitful in research, institution-building, and activism, while also arguing that it depoliticises language endangerment by turning the crisis into a technical problem.

As a point of departure to address the issue of language loss, he offers a new approach by examining the issue of ‘language oppression’: “The enforcement of language loss by physical, mental, social and spiritual coercion.” (p. 4). Unlike endangerment linguistics, Roche’s approach considers the world system and the way it consistently restricts people’s choices about language. He examines “how constrained choice is produced through networks of power that connect the world system, the state, the community, and the family...” and “how people’s choices about language are restricted by violence, domination, subordination, marginalization, and exclusion, and how this consistently leads to language loss in community...country...around the world.” (p. 4).

Considering language as a social and political institution, and carving ideas from sociolinguistics, linguistic anthropology and political theory, he is inspired by Foucault’s stance to examine power relations from the bottom up. On the methodological front, following Standpoint Theory, he examines the lived experiences of the Tibetan people in his analysis of power relations in Tibet from the state to individual speakers, to contest rather than understand language oppression or merely “reproducing the voices of those people” (p. 8).

Roche calls his approach militant, decolonial anthropology, intending to achieve what the speakers “want for themselves and their languages,” he builds his theory of a biopolitical approach to understanding language oppression to combat it and to support language maintenance and reclamation as an alternative to the approaches of endangerment linguistics “to produce a better world, rather than a better anthropology...” (p. 6). *The Politics of Language Oppression in Tibet* resonates with the political anthropology of language, analogous to the sociology of language.

Roche begins his chapter *in medias res* - “I can understand you.” He points to ‘rupture’ in the intergenerational transmission of Manegacha language¹ between the speaking parents and their non-speaking but Manegacha understanding children. It also points to a language shift among the Tibetans. In his pursuit to comprehend the rupture, he begins to address how parents’ choices, circumstances, etc., are moulded by power, and how power shapes people’s choices regarding language in Tibet and the People’s Republic of China (PRC) and globally.

Like English, Hindi and Chinese, Tibetan is ethnically and linguistically diverse rather than a monolithic construct as it portrays. In Tibet, there are more than thirty distinct languages (like Namuyi, Ngandehua, Manegacha, etc.) - ‘minoritized language’ in addition to Tibetan and Tibetan Sign Language by the Tibetan community. In the PRC, the Tibetan community, one of the fifty-six minorities (*minzu*), is considered a single population with the Tibetan language (and subordinate to the Han people and Mandarin). In turn, the thirty distinct languages of the Tibetan community face the state’s ‘erasure’: “wilful, deliberate omission of these languages from discourse and policies” (p. 13). Roche shows how the PRC manoeuvres Tibetan as both an oppressed (*vis-à-vis* the Han people and language) and an oppressor (*vis-à-vis* thirty distinct languages and their speakers belonging to the Tibetan community). He reflects on “the predicament of these languages, and many others, is primarily the result of the state’s distinction between compulsory, optional, and erased languages” (p. 72). Further, he argues that language “oppression operates by distorting people’s perceptions and analysis of their own predicament” (p. 8).

In order to understand and contest language oppression, the book explores linguistic ideologies and practices in ‘the regime of sovereign power’ in Tibet before 1958, and in ‘the regime of biopower’ under the PRC (see Arpi, 2001, for Tibet’s history). It has been found that, despite

¹ Manegacha is the name of a small minority language spoken by Tibetans in Qinghai on the northeastern Tibetan Plateau.

the use of various ‘minoritized’ languages in everyday activities for centuries, Tibetan has facilitated communication across numerous communities among the Tibetans. After the spread of Buddhism in Tibet, Tonmi Sambhota (traditionally credited as “the supposed inventor of the Tibetan writing system”) borrowed the then Brahmi-derived Gupta script (now known as the Sambhota script), which was adopted to write the Tibetan language (see Arpi, 2001: 28 for the old Brahmi script of the pre-Buddhist era). The script was meant to serve the correct and exact pronunciation of Buddhist texts, mainly by monks, to mediate connections with cosmic entities, as in the Vedic tradition, and to spread Buddhism. In contrast to this ideology, the written and the spoken Tibetan languages not only differed but also assumed different statuses and roles over time. In pre-1958 Tibet, those who wielded sovereign power—local rulers, self-governing communities and monasteries—were multiple and limited, and the linguistic repertoire of the specific individuals in the defined contexts was targeted. Roche shows that language oppression was not a social reality then.

After the downfall of the sovereign power, the post-1958 Tibet saw the establishment of ‘the regime of biopower’ under the PRC, where the older institutions were replaced by the ‘state racism’—a technique of rule, targeting the population rather than the individuals. Mandarin, which is not the native speech of any community nor of the Han majority community, but created for political purposes, was promoted as the national language, made compulsory in education and projected as the language of progress, modernity and science. Although the languages of the *minzu* were recognised constitutionally, any other minoritised language of the *minzu*, like Manegacha of the Tibetan community, is not recognised. The Tibetan power brokers, as well as elites, too advocated “for recognising Tibetan as a single group with a common language, culture, customs, and territory,” which is coherent with the PRC’s state racism. In addition, all other languages fell within the penumbra of Mandarin, leading to code-switching, hybridity, and pervasive language anxiety among non-Mandarin mother-tongue speakers. Thus, through the case studies of the various communities, Roche shows that the PRC’s state racism denies the existence of these languages, erases them from discourse, and were slated for elimination.

Tibetan identity is not a new phenomenon among the Tibetans, but aligns with the aspects of identity within ‘the regime of sovereign power’ in Tibet. In 2008, Tibetans in Tibet protested in support of the Tibetan nation’s distinct status within the PRC, rather than accepting the Chinese state’s monolithic projection of the Tibetans. These protests also echoed

forms of Tibetan nationalism in existence before the PRC, as well as the Tibetan nationalism developed in exile after 1958.

Interestingly, this contemporary Tibetan identity, which emerged as a resistance to state power and through the state power, although it seems novel, is a united aspiration renewing “awareness of nationality, culture and territory” among the Tibetans. Both Tibetan nationalism in the PRC and in exile, which projects a homogenous identity devaluing diversity, is a double-edged sword: fuelling nation-building as well as lacking resistance to the PRC’s state racism.

Roche points out that linguistic pluralism was taken for granted in earlier times. On the other hand, with the advent of Tibetan nationalism in the PRC, along with “territory, descent, participation, and essence” (p. 64), the Tibetan language emerged as its stable, core feature and the foremost amongst the other multiple identities of the Tibetans. Further, this “philological nationalism,” coupled with linguistic purism, has resulted in “*pakay tsangma*” (pure father tongue), though it acknowledges Sanskrit as its heritage and prestige. In addition to its role as a sacred language and grammar, and as a source of wisdom, and in its study as a religious enterprise, “*pakay tsangma*,” undoubtedly, is not only a Sinophobic lexical purism, but also of other ‘minoritized’ languages of the Tibetan community.

Tibetan nationalism, further, finds its articulation in pop music, asserting “a link between the Tibetan language, script and nation” (p. 70). It also leads to the anthropomorphisation of language, social ostracism, punitive measures, and self-immolation. Roche discusses the Tibetan nationalist movement, where Tibetanness is defined and defended to avoid annihilation as a race war. He argues that this race war is an act of state violence as it is not a choice of the Tibetans, but a condition forced upon them to participate. Although it is aimed at the state, it contributes to the elimination of the ‘minoritized’ languages. This, in turn, resonates with the PRC’s objective.

After the exile of His Holiness Dalai Lama to India in 1959, global Tibetophonie (akin to Francophonie), a worldwide socio-political group, emerged to promote Tibet’s cause, promoting Tibetan as the sole language of the Tibetan community. Although the Central Tibetan Administration (CTA) in Dharamsala does not have a formal language policy, through its Department of Religion and Culture, Department of Education, Department of Information and International Relations, the Tibet Policy Institute, support groups like International Tibet Network, etc., campaign for the Tibetan language rather than also for the minoritised languages of

the Tibetan community. In other words, the Tibetophonie does not critique or resist but resonates with the PRC's objective.

India not only hosts the Tibetan refugees but also supports the CTA's initiative regarding education, language, culture, etc., where only Tibetan figures prominently. Apart from historical, religious and geo-political motives, the Indian view on language seems to be based on the CTA's view rather than its own, neglecting the linguistic tapestry of the Tibetans. The latter would contradict its support for the Tibetan cause. Roche argues that all these actors amplify the PRC's objective.

By exploring the imagined lives of three generations from one family of Manegacha speakers, Roche retells the local history of state-building and the emergence of the biopolitical state in three periods: 'the communal period' (1958-1981), 'the economic liberalisation period' (1982-2000) and 'the intense market developmentalism period' (2000 onwards). The communal period witnessed two significant campaigns - the Great Leap Forward and the Cultural Revolution. In this period, the Tibetan language corpus planning took place, aimed at pruning the feudal aspects in the language and introducing the political vocabulary, and synchronising spoken and written forms of Tibetan. This resulted in modern Tibetan being lexically and grammatically distinct from the written classical Tibetan. Importantly, Tibetan grew in symbolic power and prestige, reflecting modernity and means of education, cited as a literary language too. On the other hand, Mandarin too was imposed on the speakers.

In 'the economic liberalisation period,' Manegacha speakers were stigmatised and discriminated against based on their linguistic repertoire - "neither good Tibetan, nor good Mandarin" (p. 106). With the advent of the new electronic media, the Tibetan language entered the Manegacha homes, replacing their folk institutions, and Manegacha continued to be further excluded. From 2000 onwards, Roche shows that Tibetan gained prominence over the Manegacha-language media in the emerging media, although this process had originally begun with the dominance of Mandarin in higher education, in built environment, the linguistic landscape, etc., ultimately leading to the erasure of Menegacha from the public space.

Roche also examines negative stereotypes, aggressive, hate-mongering in the social media, slurs, jokes, insults, basically discrimination and prejudice against Manegacha speakers in particular, and the 'minoritized' languages in general. He explores dehumanisation, a form of language oppression, which deprives the Manegacha speakers not only of being Tibetans, but also of being human, and reduces them to things, monsters, or animals.

On the linguistic front, identified and labelled on shibboleth, a telltale linguistic feature that enables someone to identify a speaker and their speech variety, the language is reduced to noise, animal sounds, or ghost-talk, mixed language (vs. pure language), languageless, disparagement humour, in everyday life. As a matter of fact, it is considered a threat to the Tibetan language and culture. Hence, there is monitoring and disciplining known as accentism.

On the other hand, trivialisation (downplay), positivization (highlighting positive effects) and naturalisation (blaming self and context rather than the perpetrators), further internalise the subordination, which is viewed as a social phenomenon, and its internalisation, which is immune to critique, is personal rather than political. From the Manegacha standpoint, it is a war of elimination of possibilities on “what might be otherwise.”

Building his theory, Roche argues that state-building is “a slow-moving war consisting of trends and patterns rather than events and incidents” (p. 115) to establish a biopolitical state, promoting Han supremacy as a war of state racism where Tibetan nationalism is a “race war of resistance” to the PRC’s objectives.

As a form of infrastructural violence, the “Manegacha speakers reflect on the predicament of their language...rather than the structural support network that the language has been denied” (p. 117). Roche projects that rather than on “the predicament of the language and its speakers,” it is the state that “denied utility through racist state-building.” In addition, the ‘minoritized’ speakers, like Manegacha, are abandoned by the state, and the violence against them by their acquaintances and friends, who behave as “petty sovereigns,” amounts to banal violence. Paradoxically, all these practices are empowered and sanctioned by and towards the state’s objective, resulting in a “biosovereign assemblage.” Invoking Foucault’s governmentality, through choices, hopes, desires, expectations, plans and actions rather than explicit laws or force, the individual people are governed. Further, he aims to combat language oppression: resolve conflicts and contradictions within the community (Fishman’s ideological clarification) to overcome the revitalisation paradox (i.e. the predicament of desire without action) and to overcome fear produced by the state as a part of its governmentality through “endurance” by speaking their language. In turn, he enlarges the scope of language reclamation as a social movement, where understanding the political history of the state is imperative to revitalise language through activism, networking and importantly through solidarity’s effectiveness in exposing, resisting and

interrupting the power flow at the multiple sites of the global circuit. He also points out that it is essential to combat “broader political developments” so that activism continues in the increasingly hostile environment.

The Politics of Language Oppression in Tibet is based on Roche’s fieldwork in Tibet for more than eight years, supported by grants from various universities and institutions, as mentioned in his acknowledgements (p. ix). He has incorporated already published materials, but not exactly as they were published. It is enriched with figures (photos and maps), tables, lyrics, a note on transcription, followed by 40 and 41 pages of endnotes and references, respectively. Though an index is missing, it is supplemented with quotes and pointers to make reading pleasant. He has made use of Tibetan and other speech forms, proverbs, etc., as well as script and innovatively — (m-dash) for slur and has made his reader well acquainted with various socio-cultural institutions, belief systems and conceptual categories, curating the reader’s curiosity and necessity as well as to present the community’s worldview. In a similar vein, several concepts and theories from various disciplines are well described and easily accessible to lay readers, too.

Anchoring on his engagement with “how this form of government emerged and how it enables *the state* to carry out its biopolitical imperatives” (p. 153, *italics mine*), and “broader political developments,” in the context of contemporary India, Roche has mentioned Hindutva in the wake of cultural nationalism, but not its language ideology, the role assigned to Sanskrit, and the refuting of the language families and even language endangerment (see Bharatiya Bhasa Samiti, 2025: 12, and its critique in Kidwai, 2026; Annamalai, 2026; Devy, 2026).

On a more serious note, it is also essential to look into the Tibetan government in its past and in the present. An idea of Tibet is differently conceptualised by the Tibetans. It is not a Eurocentric perspective, not even an Indic one (see Abbi 2022), and none can impose or preconceive on what it should be or ought to be or what is expected or its lack of precedence. As is known, the Tibetan approach is based on the dyad of Priest-Patron (*choe-yon*) relationship (see Arpi, 2001: 58), both in its internal and external world affairs, as well as in the domains of cosmic forces. It is upon this dyad that language ideology and nationalism — Tibetan and its constituent communities, Tibet and the Tibetan language, and Tibetan language and script, as well as nation and autonomy or even sojourn (p. 25, fn. 24, p. 168) and even ‘Tibetanization’ are predicated. Tibetan language, in contrast to Mandarin, has a history and legacy that connect past and

present, temporal and spiritual (including healing amulets), and relates to written as visible speech (see Brookes 2023 also). Moreover, it also serves the Priest-Patron relationship in the PRC, as it does in relation to Sanskrit. Drawing an analogy, on the lighter vein, Roche coins the term *singua franca* (akin to *lingua franca*) to mean ‘Tibetan written lyrics memorised for singing.’ Similarly, it can be extended to the script as a *script franca* (of the Tibetic languages whose host communities are under the suzerainty of His Holiness the Dalai Lama, also called ‘Tibetanization’).

The philological and the philosophical dimensions of script, the written ‘Sacred Scripture,’ have been integral to its imagination since the reign of Thori Nyatsen of the Yarlung dynasty in the fifth century AD. Historically, the title “Inventor of Written Script” (see Arpi, 2001: 61) was conferred on Choegyal Phagpa, and Tonmi Sambhota’s mission to India suggests the significance of the *graphic politics* (see Choksi, 2021, and its review in Sinha, 2024; contra Abbi, 2022; Das, 2024; van Schaik, 2011) and as a recurring theme of the Tibetan pop music. Hence, the script has ideological, material, as well as (spi)ritual significance, unlike in the phonocentric world. It is this form of nationalism, which is not afresh but a paradigmatic shift, may we call it ‘*graphic nationalism*’ or ‘*scriptorial nationalism*’ (contra philological nationalism) that eschews speeches for script, or diversity for unity, even intra for inter in the contemporary political scenario where ‘free Tibet’ is more pressing, reflecting ‘thick’ and ‘pragmatic solidarity’ of the oppressed *minzu* people and their ‘banished’ members in Tibet and of the Tibetan refugees in exile. However, I leave this under-discussed idea open for further exploration.

Gerald Roche’s *The Politics of Language Oppression in Tibet* is not only a pioneering work in the study of language oppression in Tibet, but also has a global call, knocking, stimulating, awakening, and activating the spirit to think enough to pursue making “a better world.” In a way, it also reinforces the belief that linguistics can address contemporary problems by translating them into terms that our tools are especially equipped to address (Dasgupta 1999). It is one of the finest books that I have read, and it has made my own deliberations on endangered languages (see Sinha, 2020; Sinha & Turin, *in press*) paler and shallower. It made me review it to combat language oppression.

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ALEX MCKAY is a retired historian with a Ph.D. in South Asian History from SOAS, University of London. His interests centre on the political and religious history of the Indo-Tibetan Himalayas. The author of a number of books and more than 40 articles on the region, his most recent works are *The Mandala Kingdom: A Political History of Sikkim* (Rachna books 2021) and a travel memoir *In Search of Mount Kailas: travels in the sacred Himalaya* (Sunrider Press/Rachna books 2025), which was awarded the 2026 Kekoo Naoroji Book Award by the Himalayan Club.

SAMAR SINHA is an assistant professor and teaches linguistics and semiotics in the Department of Nepali at Sikkim University. He obtained his Ph.D. from the Centre for Linguistics, Jawaharlal Nehru University, New Delhi, on descriptive-cum-theoretical study of Indian Sign Language, which was later published as *Indian Sign Language: an analysis of its grammar* (Gallaudet University Press, 2018). He is interested in features and their relation to architecture and modality in syntactic theory, primarily driven by the data from signed languages, Nepali language varieties and endangered languages. He collaborates with speakers of endangered languages of the Himalayas to document and describe their institutions, and with writers on translation. His other interests are in Writing Studies and the semiotics of well-being, power, identity, foodways and urban legends. Currently, he heads the Centre for Endangered Languages at Sikkim University, which researches the endangered languages of North Bengal and Sikkim.